



One IT Serving Many - Using ITSM to Drive Organizational Change and Align a Federated IT Organization

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Abstract

Our mission: Unify a university IT environment by consolidating over 600 IT staff utilizing more than eight work management systems onto a single platform. The goal was to harmonize these systems, standardize our metrics, and establish consistent processes to enhance the support we provide to over 40,000 customers.

Our key learnings:

- (1) **Formula for success:** [The right platform/technology] + [a clear and firmly executive supported strategy and vision] + [a well-researched implementation partner choice] + [relentless communication and dialogue] + [the right team] = [transformational change and unification].
- (2) **Know your WHY:** If your WHY doesn't resonate at all impacted levels of the organization, you've built your Change Castle on a foundation of sand. The ideal state is where an affected individual can see the through-line from the changes on their desk to their department's goals and the organization-wide strategies and goals. Building the through-line requires communicating the WHY using their frame of reference. Relentlessly find excuses (aka invest in Organizational Change Management [OCM]) to keep sharing the WHY in the language of that audience.
- (3) **Have the right brains:** This project had a great diversity of thought and the necessary expertise by staffing the core team with subject matter experts (SMEs). These included an organization-savvy IT leader, a respected voice from the OSU Distributed IT community, a ServiceNow platform expert, a

well-versed IT Service Management (ITSM) representative, a certified organizational change manager, and an enterprise-level project manager. Each role brought unique skills and perspectives to the project, contributing to its success.

- (4) **Seek out the conflict:** Use the WHY to build consensus. More importantly, use the WHY as a searchlight to actively find the points of contention, tension, and resistance. Addressing these points as early as possible is not just a necessity, it's a strategy. It's how you strengthen your WHY, make stakeholders feel heard, and genuinely address their concerns.
- (5) **Good enough is good enough:** Set and manage minimalist expectations for the initial implementation and then ruthlessly hold the line on that scope. Going live with a less-than-perfect solution is the fastest path to providing better service to customers and ITIL staff. It is also the quickest path to a unified IT support environment, which sets the stage for the entire organization to benefit from incremental platform enhancements, driving better ROI on those enhancements. This practical and efficient approach ensures that we deliver results without unnecessary delays.

CCS Concepts

• **Social and professional topics** → **Project and people management**; *Centralization / decentralization*.

Keywords

ITSM, IT Service Management, Organizational Change Management, IT consolidation, digital transformation, ITIL, federated IT, standardization, implementation, project management, ServiceNow

ACM Reference Format:

Lucas Friedrichsen, Terralyn Vandetta, Andrew Wheeler, Carolyn Rothwell, Sean Bangs, Alex Merino, and Kirsten Petersen. 2025. One IT Serving Many - Using ITSM to Drive Organizational Change and Align a Federated IT



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SIGUCCS '25, Denver, CO, USA

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ACM ISBN 979-8-4007-1060-5/25/04

<https://doi.org/10.1145/3675229.3712528>

Organization. In *Proceedings of the 2025 ACM SIGUCCS Annual Conference (SIGUCCS '25)*, April 06–09, 2025, Denver, CO, USA. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 4 pages. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3675229.3712528>

1 The Challenge

Oregon State University (OSU) has over 600 IT professionals, including 200 student employees, working in Central IT and Distributed IT, serving more than 40,000 students, faculty, and staff. The existing IT service environment included over eight distinct IT work management systems spread across 50 different departments. There are significant differences in structure, budgeting lines, and lines of authority between OSU's Centralized and Distributed IT groups. While centralized and distributed communities desire and act as a unified community representing OSU IT, they have significantly different decision-makers and decision-making processes.

Operational impacts included:

- Customers experienced different service levels and often didn't know which group to contact.
- No ability to share or transfer tickets across IT groups on different technology platforms.
- No system-supported way for IT groups to surge support across groups.
- No overall picture of IT support volume across the University.
- No clear university-level metrics, e.g. Cost/IT Ticket.
- A bloated IT Request catalog of 185 request forms created a confusing choice environment for customers.
- No university-level coordinated support environment for the upcoming university-wide Administrative Modernization Program, which aims to replace OSU's core administrative systems.

2 Intended Outcomes

By unifying the approach to ITSM, the project sought to elevate the customer experience, mitigate the impact of organizational silos, increase information sharing/transparency, and promote a culture of cross-functional teamwork. This collaboration encourages knowledge transfer, amplifies problem-solving capacities, and facilitates the rapid dissemination of best practices throughout OSU IT. The intended outcomes for the project included:

- **Enhanced User Experience:** All users across the university will experience similar service levels, ensuring consistent and equitable IT support.
- **Accessible content:** During the rebuilding of content and workflows in the new system, the teams will focus on creating accessible content and navigation. This effort will complement the alignment with the new WCAG standards outlined in the IT Accessibility Policy.
- **Better staff experience:** OSU IT staff will benefit from fit-to-standard ITSM practices. Sharing a single platform will enable OSU IT staff to collaborate on specific requests, understand trends better, and help each other during times of shifting demand.

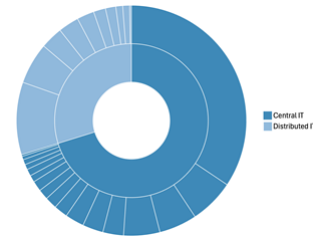


Figure 1: OSU IT Landscape

- **Reduced technical complexity:** Reducing the number of duplicative software applications in our environment enhances our security posture and reduces administrative overhead.
- **Increased Capacity:** Implementing efficient IT service management practices will increase capacity by streamlining processes, minimizing downtime, and optimizing resource utilization.
- **Increased Productivity:** Effective ITSM practices can enhance employee productivity by reducing time spent on resolving incidents or managing changes.
- **Improved economies of scale:** Making investments and improvements to a single platform benefits the entire community.
- **Improved metrics and reporting:** Metrics will be more accessible when OSU IT staff utilize a single platform. This data will enable IT leadership to understand operations more efficiently, use data to inform decisions for continuous improvement, and provide critical insights to OSU leadership.

3 The Journey

Project work began in earnest August 2023. However, the Sponsor and team quickly realized that the vision and scope had not been sharply defined enough to provide the actionable framework the project team needed. After calling a time out in the execution, the team reformed and realigned itself to the concepts of choosing a best-in-class platform and creating a shared OSU platform by implementing a "Fit to Standard", or "Out of The Box" strategy.

Previously, ServiceNow was selected through a Request For Proposal (RFP) process and utilized for areas outside of ITSM. In November 2023, ServiceNow was re-confirmed as the technology platform of choice for ITSM, based on price, performance and other factors. Key data in this decision came from interviewing other organizations that had completed the transition OSU was embarking on. Input from the executive-level staff within OSU and peer institutions was another key to OSU's alignment with selecting InSource as an implementation partner. The selection of the implementation partner was a highly impactful decision in the most positive sense.

With clear alignment on platform and strategy, coupled with the beginning of relentless OCM across all the potential university stakeholders, the team kicked off the formal work in February 2024.

In four and a half months, OSU partnered with InSource to progress steadily through the typical stages of the Go Live platform. The first wave included approximately one-third of OSU IT with

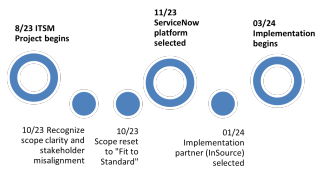


Figure 2: Pre-Project Execution Timeline



Figure 3: Project Execution Timeline

both central and distributed IT groups and the OSU Service Desk, which serves the largest volume of requests within the OSU IT.

Wave 2 included nearly all the remaining OSU IT groups and went live in August 2024 on the same configuration used for Wave 1. At the time of this paper, the project team has completed “hypercare” and are moving to cleaning up the remaining touchpoints in the legacy processes. In partnership with InSource, OSU is also investing in a “Fall Enhancement Cycle,” to address the most desired configuration upgrades and Request Catalog enhancements. This final phase of the project will be complete by the end of December 2024.

4 Key Decisions and Actions

Several critical decisions and actions on the project have materially contributed to our success. These include:

- (1) **Scope clarity:** Calling “time out” when the initial launch into execution highlighted the need for more planning and refinement of scope and approach.
- (2) **Scope clarity:** Ultimately bounding implementation scope closely to the out-of-the-box configuration. This was a touchstone the team came back to repeatedly when debating how to proceed in making a multitude of tactical decisions. The shared message, “Let’s come together on one platform so we can move forward together.”
- (3) **Platform:** Selecting an industry-leading platform as the future environment.
- (4) **Partner choice:** Researching and selecting an implementation partner, as measured by positive feedback from prior partners and peers. The key data came from those working most closely with the partner versus executive opinions.
- (5) **Platform Agnostic Training:** Engaged a third-party consultant to provide a customized ITSM training that was completely disconnected from the selected platform. Focused on building a foundational language and thinking about process across the institution. This was the first step to avoid a lift-and-shift approach.

- (6) **Go Live strategy:** The strategy called for Wave 1 to Go Live with 1/3 of the University. This wave deliberately included the OSU Service Desk, the largest volume group and two Distributed IT groups whose leaders are influencers among the OSU Distributed IT community.
- (7) **Invest in OCM:** The project core team included a Prosci-certified OCM owner at 0.25 FTE. This investment was fundamental to the project success and was a force multiplier, producing >100 different communications in six months from Day 1 to Wave 2 Go Live. The OCM workstream was integral to the project versus something to dabble in.
- (8) **Project Team membership:** From Day 1/Project Kickoff, despite going live with only 1/3 of the University for Wave 1, we deliberately and consistently included project team members representing a majority of the OSU IT community. While this did result in difficulty scheduling meetings for a project team of 17 members, it helped build consensus over time and ensured we heard all voices in a timely manner.
- (9) **Efficient decisions:** A team of 17 was not an efficient quorum to make tactical decisions, e.g., the detailed workflow on a Request form, however we wanted/needed to keep the whole team engaged as the story unfolded. Our solution was to overtly form a 5-6 person working team whose charter was to develop the detailed flows and then bring that back for comment/input from the larger team before submitting the flow for configuration.
- (10) **Embrace the conflict:** We took to heart some coaching from the OSU CIO. She advised our project lead “This project is bringing great change to IT, if you’re not having difficult conversations, you’re not properly addressing the magnitude of change.” This was part of the reasoning for including IT leaders from across IT groups from Day 1 of the project. We deliberately stated a team norm that we needed to seek and collegially work through points of dissonance. We kept repeating this with the team, including having “sensing sessions”, which were meetings solely to listen to what they were thinking. This also allowed us to identify the conflicts and concerns as early as possible. We triaged and treated this feedback much like one would in User Acceptance Testing (UAT). Project team input was classified as one of the following: a bug to be fixed, a future enhancement, or a training item, with the training being education on why it’s an issue that is already being managed. Through these sessions, we learned things we might have missed, and we helped transition key stakeholders who started with resistance to being true champions of the change.
- (11) **Put your executives to work:** Between weekly status updates and Steering Committee meetings every 1-1.5 months, we had an engaged and informed suite of executives who were positioned to actively support the project. They made the timely decisions we asked for, as well as proselytizing to the IT community about the benefits of choosing to join this platform.

Other key OCM measures:

- (12) Created a “Public Bulletin Board” in the form of a project communications SharePoint site immediately after the project kickoff.
- (13) Viewed each project milestone, e.g. UAT, as an opportunity for at least three OCM pulses:
 - “Here’s what will be happening and what your role will be.”
 - “Here’s what is currently happening and what you need to know/do.”
 - “Here’s what we just finished doing and where that puts us in terms of project progress.”
- (14) Coordinated “spontaneous” emails from the Executive Sponsor/CIO. At high-leverage moments, e.g. soliciting UAT volunteers, Train the Trainer, Go Live, we ghost-wrote emails of encouragement for our Executive Sponsor and CIO to send to the IT community.
- (15) Used an OCM Activity Register to proactively build out our backlog of communication products to be built and shared. Leveraged the technique where each project plan milestone was at least a three-communication opportunity.
- (16) Learned when standard terminology didn’t work. We originally described our Go Live configuration as a “minimum

VIABLE product”, but some stakeholders were internalizing “MINIMUM viable product”. We listened and adapted by referring to the configuration approach as “out of the box” and “a good foundation”, which served our audience well.

- (17) Moderate a weekly ITSM user forum that encourages sharing by community members, another space to hear concerns, questions, share updates, and provide best practices.
 - Provided regular 5–10-minute updates in standing IT community forums, which resulted in 1-2 updates per month.
- (18) Conducted sensing sessions with Wave 2 IT group representatives at the start of the Wave 2 requirements gathering. These were open forums with the agenda of “tell us what’s on your mind”. A stated purpose of the meetings was that we wanted a community of psychological safety where folks could “say the thing.” Openly and repeatedly declaring our desire for that shared safe place, and reacting accordingly when a stakeholder engaged in that manner created a lot of trust and open communication.

Received 3 October 2024; revised 19 November 2024; accepted 22 January 2024